

PEACE STUDIES JOURNAL

Volume 13, Issue 1
May 2020

THE MEDIA, VIOLENCE AND PEACEBUILDING IN MEXICO. QUANTITATIVE PHASE OF THE RESEARCH

Authors: Mauricio Meschoulam, Andrea Muhech, Tania Naanous, Sofia Quintanilla, Jorge Ochoa, Ángel Valle, Michelle Kawa, Luisa Castillo, and Yolanda Barrita

1. Author: Mauricio Meschoulam, PhD.

Titles: Director, Professor

Affiliation: Mexico Research Center for Peace, Universidad Iberoamericana

Location: Mexico City, Mexico

Primary email: mauricio@cipmex.org

2. Co-Author: Andrea Muhech

Titles: Coordinator

Affiliation: Mexico Research Center for Peace

Location: Mexico City, Mexico

Primary email: andreamuhech@cipmex.org

3. Co-Author: Tania Naanous

Titles: Researcher

Affiliation: Mexico Research Center for Peace

Location: Mexico City, Mexico

Primary email: tania.naanous@cipmex.org

4. Co-Author: Sofia Quintanilla

Titles: Researcher

Affiliation: Mexico Research Center for Peace

Location: Mexico

Primary email: sofia.quintanilla@cipmex.org

5. Co-Author: Jorge Ochoa

Titles: Researcher

Affiliation: Mexico Research Center for Peace

Location: The Hague, Netherlands

Primary email: jorge.ochoa.u@gmail.com

6. Co-Author: Angel Valle
Title: Researcher
Affiliation: Mexico Research Center for Peace
Location: Mexico City
Primary email: valleangel92@gmail.com

7. Co-Author: Michelle Kawa
Title: Researcher
Affiliation: Mexico Research Center for Peace
Location: Mexico City, Mexico
Primary email: michelle@cipmex.org

8. Co-Author: Luisa Castillo
Titles: Researcher
Affiliation: Mexico Research Center for Peace
Location: Mexico City, Mexico
Primary email: Luisa.castgav@hotmail.com

9. Co-Author: Yolanda Barrita
Titles: Partner and Statistics Research Coordinator
Affiliation: Lexia Insights & Solutions
Location: Mexico City, Mexico
Primary email: yolanda@lexia.com.mx

Keywords: Peacebuilding, Peace Journalism, Psychosocial Effects, Mass Media, Violence in Mexico

Acknowledgements

We thank the Lexia Insights & Solutions quantitative team for their essential collaboration in this study.

Abstract

Mexico is one of the 25 least peaceful countries on Earth, which has had significant psychosocial impacts on the population. The present study explored those psychosocial impacts in a national representative sample. In addition, a statistical model was developed to determine the factors which had the greatest impact on generating negative or positive feelings after contact with the news. Results indicate that most Mexicans prefer to distance themselves from the traditional news media and use other means to socially construct their understanding of their surroundings or, even, opt to avoid being informed. The perception that the government and the media manipulate information, as well as perceived sensationalism, predict the prevalence of negative feelings after contact with the news. In contrast, the perception that a media outlet contributes to peacebuilding diminishes negative feelings. This study contributes evidence to support suggestions designed to address these circumstances, including recommendations for peace journalism.

I. Introduction

We usually tend to understand peace based on what it is not; we consider it the state in which there is no war or violent conflict. However, we do not always evaluate the active components of peace that produce and sustain peaceful conditions. Following authors such as Galtung (1985), the Institute for Economics and Peace (IEP, 2018) explains that there is an angle or aspect of peace that is negative and another that is positive. Negative peace—that which must not be present in order for a society to be living in peace—involves the absence of violence as well as the absence of fear of violence. In contrast, positive peace consists of the factors that compose, activate, and sustain peaceful societies. The IEP has conducted research demonstrating eight basic areas measured by 24 indicators that are present in the most peaceful societies around the world. These are known as the eight pillars of peace or, in other words, the DNA of peace: “(A) A well-functioning government; (b) Equitable distribution of resources; (c) Free flow of information; (d) Good relations with neighbors; (e) High levels of human capital; (f) Acceptance of the rights of others; (g) Low levels of corruption; (h) A sound business environment” (IEP, 2018, 52). Ekanola (2012) put it this way: several conditions, both objective and subjective, must be met for a society to be deemed peaceful. Objective conditions include physical safety, material prosperity and social harmony, while subjective conditions involve the emotional wellbeing of people.

Mexico has, for several years, been among the 25 least peaceful countries in the world (Institute for Economics and Peace [IEP], 2018). This has very diverse causes and implications. On one hand, as stated above, the weakness of the active components of peace lie at the bottom of the structural factors that produce such circumstances. On the other, a fear of violence is produced among the population, with all of the psychosocial and political repercussions this entails. However, peace or its absence, comprises interconnected variables: Violence produces fear. Fear, in turn, has negative impacts on inclusion, democracy, and structural peace (Canetti-Nisim, Halperin, Sharvit, & Hobfoll, 2009; Ceobanu, Wood, & Ribeiro, 2010; Demombynes, 2009; IEP 2018, 2019; Ley, 2015a, 2015b; Morris, 2012, 2013; Siegel, 2007; Wilson, 2004; Wolf, 2016). Likewise, a lack of structural peace is an essential component of the conditions of violence, which, once again, produce fear (IEP 2018, 5). Where, then, do we begin to break the circle?

The best answer is probably that there is no single answer. Peace, as we said, consists of multiple components. Therefore, it makes sense to study, understand, and work to build, correct, or activate those components. One of those components has to do with how we perceive violence, how we communicate it, how we understand it, the psychosocial effects it produces and, ultimately, the political impact that all of the above generate.

This study seeks to contribute to this area by complementing a series of prior investigations carried out and published over the years by the Mexico Research Center for Peace (Centro de Investigación para la Paz México [CIPMEX]) using a quantitative instrument applied with the collaboration of Lexia Insights & Solutions (LIS) to a representative national sample in Mexico about perceptions and conceptions regarding the most important media outlets in the country, regarding how violence is communicated and understood by the population, and regarding the role said media play or should play in building peace. Thus, this study cannot be understood in an isolated manner, without telling the story of which it is a part. In the following pages, we will tell that story and discuss the background that contextualizes this investigation in order to provide

relevance for the reader. We will then describe the methodology, followed by the findings, a discussion, and recommendations.

Our aim can be summarized as follows: if Mexico (or countries such as Mexico, unfortunately subsumed by violence due to different causes) wants to understand and reverse its peaceless situation, it is essential to study, more in-depth, the different problematics it experiences. This understanding cannot be reduced to high rates of murder or violent crimes but, rather, involve structural factors such as institutional weakness, socioeconomic inequality or prevailing corruption, and also include the psychosocial impact that is generated as a result of how violence is communicated and perceived. This is what the following sections deal with.

II. Background and Conceptual Framework

As we have stated, this study is the quantitative phase that complements a series of prior studies. Therefore, rather than carrying out statistical tests based on a pre-existing theoretical framework, we seek to validate results obtained from these previous qualitative studies and perform statistical research to better understand those results. In this section we describe the conceptual framework on which this project is based in addition to explaining how these studies evolved throughout these years.

All of the investigations described in this section take a comprehensive view of structural peace, including the system that creates and sustains positive and negative peace (Galtung, 1985; Alger, 1987; IEP, 2018). From among all of the components of negative peace and positive peace, the series of studies of which this quantitative study is a part, has been grounded in the need to explore two central topics: (a) fear and its psychosocial effects in Mexico, and (b) the perceived absence of the free flow of information, with the ultimate goal of contributing evidence to support recommendations for peacebuilding. These factors matter because, based on the evidence, the prevalence of fear and environments of stress tends to produce negative impacts on issues such as democracy, inclusion, respect for the rights of others, tolerance, trust in democracy and institutions of justice, and, in general, support for peace processes (Bateson, 2009, 2012; Canetti-Nisim, Halperin, Sharvit, & Hobfoll, 2009; Carreras, 2013; Ceobanu, Wood, & Ribeiro, 2010; Demombynes, 2009; IEP, 2018, 2019; Ley, 2015a, 2015b; Morris, 2012, 2013; Siegel, 2007; Wilson, 2004; Wolf, 2016).

As we progressed and expanded on our own studies carried out in Mexico (2011-2017), we detected the presence of several of those effects among our participants. However, as of late 2018, none of our studies had been applied to a representative sample at the national level. Therefore, our findings remained in the category of exploratory. From there came the need to carry out a new study capable of verifying whether these themes were present in broader cross-sections of the Mexican population, and use the instrument to perform specific statistical tests to better understand the previous findings. To understand this process better, it is necessary to briefly discuss the series of studies we had conducted up to the present one.

1. Exploratory study on the symptoms suggestive of posttraumatic stress disorder (PTSD) among the Mexican population (2011-2012)

This study, carried out among participants from 25 states throughout the country, found a very high incidence of symptoms suggestive of PTSD among those we surveyed as a result of the increase in violence associated with organized crime experienced in Mexico since 2006. Despite a lack of representativeness and difficulties comparing the results with the results of more ambitious and in-depth studies prior to 2006, this study seemed to suggest that the level of PTSD among the Mexican population was 20 times higher than that in years prior to the aforementioned increase in violence. Notably, our study found a very high correlation between exposure to media and symptoms suggesting PTSD, even among participants from the least violent states in Mexico. Those findings suggested the existence of a stress contagion and the presence of trauma among many of those we surveyed, caused by “learning” about violent events through the media and social networks. One out of two participants believed that the media were the principal transmitter of stress; 90% reported contact with news outlets, and 75% reported feeling worse after that contact. Among other transmitters of stress, we highlight rumors of violent acts/everyday conversation (45% of participants) and incidents experienced by people one is close to (44.5%) (Meschoulam & Calderón-Abbo, 2019, 50).

To explore these types of factors in greater depth, to understand more about the process of the social construction of values, perceptions and conceptions of violence and peace, and to further understand the role of experiences, everyday conversation, the media, the government and organized crime in the social construction of these perceptions, we initiated a series of qualitative research studies based on in-depth interviews with Mexican participants.

2. Qualitative Studies, Phases 1, 2 and 3 (2013-2015)

Phase 1 of the qualitative interviews was conducted among 15 persons residing in a Mexico City neighborhood (Meschoulam, 2014, 1). In Phase 2, we interviewed 65 more participants from another 28 different neighborhoods in Mexico City as well as 13 different states throughout the country (Meschoulam, et al. 2015, 3). Phase 3 was a case study in which we applied the same interview protocol to 25 employees of one of the best companies to work for in Mexico, seeking to determine to what extent the results could vary if the work environment were more favorable than the national average for Mexican companies (Meschoulam, et al. 2018, 2).

Despite not having used representative national samples, the most relevant aspect of these three phases of qualitative research was the frequency of repetition of 15 main categories during the interviews, regardless of the gender, occupation, geographic location, age, or socioeconomic level of the participants. These categories are summarized as follows:

- a. The main components of the social construction of participants regarding their perceptions and conceptions of the situation of violence experienced by the country and possibilities for peace, were their own experiences and observations, the conversations they had with their friends, families, work colleagues, and associates, and the experiences of people with whom they were close. These three categories alone addressed more than 60% of the content of the themes the participants discussed during the interviews.
- b. The above showed a significant contrast with the written press, radio and television as factors of social construction. These three components appeared with much lesser frequency as influential

pieces in the perceptions and conceptions of participants regarding violence and peace. This does not mean that the traditional media were not used, but that participants indicated that these media were not reliable sources for them to find out and learn about what was happening in the country compared to their own experiences, observations, and conversations with the people that they did believe. On the other hand, they expressed a great number of negative feelings such as anger, rejection, and even rage against those media, which were perceived as being part of the corrupt system that, in their view, characterized Mexico.

c. Similarly, the greatest elements of social construction of the feeling of fear or terror, one of the topics that was most present in the interviews, were personal experience and conversations with and the experiences of people with whom one is close. However, in their view, the media also played an important role in the propagation of fear, for they were sensationalist, showed too much violence and “intentionally” spread terror to control public opinion for their own interests or the interests of the government (Meschoulam, et al., 2015).

Because of the relevance of those factors in terms of the possibilities for building peace in Mexico, we decided to expand the investigation further, focusing more specifically on the issue of the media.

3. Qualitative Study, Phase 4 (2016-17): Media, Violence and Peace

The final qualitative phase (Meschoulam, et al. 2017, 1-17) consisted of in-depth interviews using an interview protocol that recaptured some of the elements of the previous protocol but, this time, exploring the media factor in much greater depth through the following questions:

To which specific TV networks, radio stations, programs, newspapers, or journalists were the participants referring? Are certain media outlets perceived differently than others? Which media sources were perceived differently and for what reasons? What makes participants respect certain media outlets and what repels them from other media? What causes frustration, apathy, anger, rage, or other negative sentiments about certain media outlets or specific journalists and how are those sentiments socially constructed? What role do social media play in this environment? What, according to study participants, should the media or journalists do to become more reliable? What topics should the media report and how should these topics be reported for the participants to decide to contact those media? From the perspective of participants, how should mass media report violence? (Meschoulam, et al. 2017, 4).

Without using a representative sample but obtaining the greatest possible diversity among our respondents, in-depth interviews with 80 participants, 40 in 35 different neighborhoods in Mexico City, and 40 in 21 different states in the interior of the country, were conducted; the participants had different ages and occupations, were from different socioeconomic sectors, and had different political preferences.

The findings of this fourth phase can be summarized as follows:

a. The distancing participants expressed with respect to the traditional news media, such as the two main television networks and the most popular radio stations and newspapers in the country, had

to do with two basic factors: (1) a lack of trust these media outlets seemed to inspire based on the perception that those media sources were manipulated by the government (which they mistrusted enormously) or by the elites in power in the country; according to that perception, the media were part of the structure of corruption, crime, and violence; and (2) a series of negative feelings that, in their view, the media produced on them, such as anger, stress, anxiety, fear, despair and apathy, among others, due to the sensationalism of those media outlets, the excessive display of violence and blood, and a lack of respect for victims of the situation Mexico was experiencing in the years in which these interviews were carried out.

b. Upon in-depth investigation, nearly all of the participants stated that despite the occasional or frequent use of the main television channels, radio stations or newspapers, they preferred to distance themselves from the news and instead access programs related to entertainment, sports, or culture. The participants, once again, told us that they had much greater trust in their own experiences and observations, their conversations with people whom they were close, and the experiences of people they knew, vis-a-vis what was published in the traditional media.

c. In contrast, the majority of the participants indicated that they felt attracted to media outlets and journalists that showed distance from the government, that demonstrated objectivity and journalistic rigor, that were capable of promoting critical thinking, that questioned the authorities, and that promoted investigative journalism unmasking corruption scandals. Likewise, the participants seemed to value, in particular, those media outlets that demonstrated respect for the victims of violence, that were not sensationalist, or did not excessively use bloody images and videos, and that, instead, promoted informed debate regarding the structural causes of violence and potential solutions for building peace in the country.

d. In the topic of social media, we detected mixed attitudes. On one hand, social networks were valued by many of our participants as alternative media for obtaining information given their strong mistrust of the corrupt system and traditional media. Social networks were also viewed by many participants as a mechanism for talking about public affairs, and the participants tended to believe their contacts on those networks—even those they did not know or had not met in person—more than the traditional media. On the other hand, however, nearly half of those we interviewed mentioned feeling mistrust in social media given the spread of fake news and the lack of mechanisms to control what is shared on those platforms. Many participants also mentioned that political actors from the corrupt system that they mistrusted, and from the traditional media, appropriated social networks through bots and fake accounts or, even, through their official accounts, making these spaces inhospitable for conversation.

The quantitative research presented in this article stems specifically from the findings of Phase 4.

III. Research Questions and Hypotheses

The present study sought to answer whether the findings from Phase 4 described above were confirmed in a national sample, and also sought to find out what were the most important contributors to the distancing between participants and the news media. First, was there a correlation between distrust in government and distrust in the media associated with perceived manipulation of information? Secondly, did such distrust in the government and the media have

any impact on the generation of negative feelings after contact with the news in traditional media (TV, radio and newspapers) such as stress, frustration, apathy, fear, anger, anxiety, discomfort, repulsion, sadness, and hopelessness? Thirdly, to what extent the perception that there is a high level of yellow journalism or sensationalism, could be found among participants of a national sample and how did that perception impact on the generation of negative feelings after the contact with the news in those media such as stress, frustration, apathy, fear, anger, anxiety, discomfort, repulsion, sadness, and hopelessness?

Finally, we sought to find out whether the trust in specific media sources, and the perception that they were not sensationalist and instead, contributed to peacebuilding, and generated a lower level of negative feelings among participants after their contact with those specific media sources.

Our hypotheses were (a) that there was a correlation between distrust in government and distrust in the main Mexican traditional news media associated with perceived manipulation of information; (b) that this distrust was one of the main sources of the generation of negative feelings such as stress, frustration, apathy, fear, anger, anxiety, discomfort, repulsion, sadness, and hopelessness among participants after their contact with the news from the mainstream traditional media of the country; (c) similarly, we assumed that another predictor of prevalence of negative feelings after contact with the news in the mainstream traditional media was the perception that these media sources display violence excessively and they are disruptors of peace; and (d) in contrast, because our study sought to explore the level of trust and closeness with specific media sources, as well as with alternative news sources such as certain Internet news portals, we assumed that as trust in specific media outlets grew as well as the perception that those specific media outlets contribute to peacebuilding, to that extent the said negative feelings were less present after contact with them.

IV. Methodology

Participants and Sampling Strategy

The target population of this survey consisted of Mexican men and women ages 18 to 65 living in the central, western, northern and southern regions of the country (that is, all regions of Mexico) whose socioeconomic level corresponds to ABC+, C, C-, D+, and DE (Asociación Mexicana de Agencias de Inteligencia de Mercado y Opinión [Mexican Association of Marketing and Public Opinion Research or AMAI], 2016) and who are exposed to more than one media outlet. In total, the target population is an estimated 59,007,333 people (CONAPO, 2018).

To represent this population, we used a stratified sample, randomly inviting participants to respond to our survey, and participants were accepted only if they were located within the desired socioeconomic and demographic strata based on the proportions designated to achieve the traits being sought. Based on national demographic data (Instituto Nacional de Estadística Geografía e Informática [National Institute for Statistics, Geography and Informatics or INEGI], 2015), the participants in our sample included 30.0% from the central region; 25.0% from the west; 23.0% from the north; and 22% from the south. Approximately 47.9% were men, and 52.1% were women. Different age ranges were represented as follows: 18 to 25 years of age, 23.0%; 26 to 35 years of age, 25.2%; 36 to 45 years of age, 22.4%; 46 to 55 years of age, 17.6%; and 56 to 65 years of age,

11.7%. Socioeconomic levels, in line with the existing data, were represented as follows: AB and C+, 17%; C and C-, 27.0%; and D+ and DE, 56% (CONAPO, 2018; AMAI, 2016).

Considering all of the above data, the margin of sampling error for 1,000 effective cases was estimated at 3.1% with 95% confidence, and the confidence intervals we expected were 0.56 and 0.43.

Data Collection

To verify the aforementioned hypotheses, we developed an instrument with closed questions and scaled responses, such as those provided in Table 1.0. The high repetition of the patterns detected in the earlier qualitative phases of this research conferred, at the qualitative level, a considerable level of reliability to those investigations. However, with the purpose of avoiding confirmation bias, all of the questions on the questionnaire offered different options to those surveyed. For example, one question asked participants to rank on a scale from 0 to 4 their level of identification with the statement “I trust the information published on a certain platform or media outlet,” which allowed them to reflect on both their level of trust as well as their possible level of mistrust. Other questions were expressly inserted into the questionnaire to introduce elements of the alternative hypotheses to the ones we assumed.

Table 1. Example of a question from the quantitative instrument

	Completely agree			Completely disagree
I like hearing the news	4	3	2	1
I prefer not to find out what is happening in the country because the news stresses me out	4	3	2	1
I do not have time to watch / listen to / read the news	4	3	2	1
If I turn on the radio or television, I prefer programs related to music, culture, entertainment or sports rather than news	4	3	2	1
I trust the news broadcast on television	4	3	2	1
I trust the news broadcast on the radio	4	3	2	1
I trust the news published in the newspapers	4	3	2	1
I trust the news published on social media	4	3	2	1
I trust the information I acquire through my own experiences and the people I know more than I trust the information that appears in media such as television, radio or newspapers	4	3	2	1
I trust the information I acquire through my own experiences and the people I know more than I trust the information that is published on social media	4	3	2	1

Regardless of whether you usually watch / hear / read the news, to what extent do you agree or disagree with the following statements?

Using scales similar to those showed in Table 1, we investigated issues such as the feelings of those surveyed following contact with news outlets, traditional media, websites and social media, that they trust most; their attitudes toward specific media outlets (such as Televisa, TV Azteca, and specific radio stations and newspapers); to what extent the information from the media is

perceived as manipulated by the government or by the media companies' own interests; the attributes most valued by participants in determining whether to access and remain in contact with a specific media outlet; which media outlets and journalists they trust most and what attributes create that trust; and other similar issues.

Considering that 65.8% of the population over age six in Mexico use the internet (INEGI, 2018), the type of survey used was an online access panel with 1,000 self-administered surveys. That is, the surveys were carried out through a closed panel in which participants received personal invitations to take the survey one time. Through this panel, the survey sample was monitored continuously to guarantee compliance with the quotas established in the sample design.

As we indicated, this platform functions through random invitations via email. Those willing to sign up fill out a form with their data and a series of questions regarding their social, economic and demographic profile. The panel we used has a high level of reliability and rigor, achieving ISO 26362 certification (Netquest, 2017, 1-6). This entails controlling the people invited through different methods that guarantee that the profile the person indicates having is effectively the profile of the person registered. As an additional filter, the panel ensured that the participants were not repeat users, that is, that they did not participate in related surveys over short periods of time.

This methodology (online access panel) and sampling strategy have been employed commonly both in Mexico as well as in other parts of the world for the application of quantitative instruments in representative samples in order to measure perceptions, attitudes, public opinion and similar issues (e.g., Hitchman, et al. 2015; IAB México, 2018; Peña & Aiassa, 2018; Rodríguez, Zorzano, Hernández, Jurado, Contreras, & Rasco, 2017; Sánchez & Segovia, 2008; Vara-Miguel, Megredo, Amoedo & Moreno 2019). Bearing this in mind, the CIPMEX team, which carried out the studies mentioned in the background section, collaborated with a team from Lexia Insights & Solutions who are experts in the use of this technology and have applied this methodology successfully, achieving publications of national relevance (Flores Thomas, 2018; Grupo de Asesores Unidos SC [GAUSSC SC] & Lexia, 2011; Lara, 2018; Robles & Salmón 2018). Finally, this study adhered to the ethical standards imposed by the Universidad Iberoamericana, with which CIPMEX is associated, as well as Mexican regulations and international regulations related to data protection and the privacy of participants. Each participant, before signing up for the online panel, read and signed an informed consent document concerning the nature of the panel and the research being carried out as well as the protection of their identity and personal information. This consent form was again authorized by each participant once they decided to answer the applied instrument.

Data Analysis and Statistical Model

In processing the data obtained in the survey, we used Survey Reporter. Additionally, the confidence level was set at to identify significant variations in responses among groups (by socioeconomic level, gender, age, and region). The statistical analyses were generated through the platform R, a specialized software.

In addition to verifying the correlation between trust in government and trust in the traditional media (TV, radio, newspapers) associated with manipulation of information, a statistical model

was designed to find out what were the characteristics attributed to the media by the participants which had the greatest impact on generating negative feelings in these participants after their contact with the news in those media outlets. For this purpose, an index was developed that we named “Negative Feelings” (NEGFeelings) (including stress, frustration, apathy, fear, anger, anxiety, discomfort, repulsion, sadness, and hopelessness, among others, that participants said were produced in them after contacting news media). Parallel to this index, a second index was developed to encompass the level of the participant’s contact with traditional media (TV, radio and newspapers). A linear regression model was then generated, in which the independent variable was the index of negative feelings (NEGFeelings), and its dependent variables were the attributes assigned to the media by participants, seeking to answer which of all the investigated attributes were the attributes that had more relevance in the provocation of negative (or positive) feelings.

Date of application of the questionnaire and why it is relevant

This study was applied between November 20 and December 5, 2018. The dates of application are relevant to the Mexican case since only on December 1, 2018 there was a change of government in the country, which is considered historical. The arrival to power of a leftist administration headed by Andrés Manuel López Obrador (AMLO), who contended for the presidency on three occasions and who was perceived for almost two decades as the main opposition to the system (Gómez Vilchis, 2013; Lajous, 2012; Muñoz Canto 2012; Valdiviezo, 2012) could have considerable impacts in terms of what this study and its background found: When our participants talked about the “government” or the “system,” or the manipulation of the media by the “government,” their reference is not to the administration of AMLO, but to what it expresses opposing. Therefore, it would be necessary to make a new application of our questionnaire after a period of that government and review whether the findings presented below change.

Profile of Our Respondents Regarding Media Consumption

The following describes the participants in terms of media consumption based on the sections of the survey that investigated this topic.

Among our participants, to obtain news, 81% use the internet; while 80% watch television; 40% listen to the radio; 30% read newspapers; and 11% read magazines. One percent stated that they did not watch, listen to or read the news.

A total of 91% read news on social media, and 9% do not use social media for that purpose. Among those who do use social networks for news, 93% do so on Facebook, 55% on YouTube, 33% on Twitter, 17% on Instagram, and 5% on Pinterest.

Sixty-seven percent obtain news from Televisa (TV network): 66% from TV Azteca, 19% from other open TV channels, and 7% from Channel 11 (Instituto Politécnico Nacional, a public university TV channel); 28% use subscription television services to watch the news, including international channels such as CNN (10%). Several of these specific media sources were used for specific questions on our survey.

Eighty-three percent listen to FM radio stations to obtain news. The most popular stations were those belonging to Radio Fórmula, EXA and Televisa Radio (which includes W Radio); 11% listen to AM stations, and 2% listen to online radio stations. As with television stations, several of these specific radio stations were used in specific questions on our survey.

Sixty-one percent indicated reading national newspapers to obtain news, and the most frequently mentioned were *El Universal*, *Milenio* and *Excélsior*; 64% use local newspapers, notably *El Norte* and *Reforma*. A total of 38% of respondents access the websites of national newspapers to obtain news. Of these, the most visited were websites for *El Universal*, *Reforma* (included here as a national website), *Milenio*, *Excélsior*, and *La Jornada*. These media are also part of what we investigated in our survey. Additionally, 21% of participants obtain news through the websites of local newspapers; 5% use the websites of international newspapers; 21% use the websites of television outlets such as CNN, Televisa or TV Azteca; and 5% use the websites of independent communicators such as Aristegui Noticias or other websites such as Animal Político.

In terms of frequency of consumption, 63% of those who use social media, 58% of those who watch television, 43% of those who listen to the radio, 23% of those who read newspapers, and 40% of those who use the internet indicated that they used them daily. Outside of television and social media, the majority of those we surveyed indicated that they consumed news media only sometimes during the week. The average news consumption among those surveyed was 104 minutes (including the use of social networks). Of note are those in the age range of 55 to 65 years of age, who consumed more than two hours of news per day.

V. Results

The results of this study indicate that the majority of Mexicans tend to mistrust the traditional news media more than they trust them (see Figure 1.0). This refers to outlets such as Televisa and TV Azteca, the country's two main television networks, and, to a lesser extent, other types of media such as the newspapers *El Universal* and *Reforma* or companies such as W Radio or Radio Fórmula, two of the country's most popular radio broadcasters. Eighty-four percent of the participants in our survey believed that the information broadcast by Televisa is manipulated by the government, while 71% believed this to be true of TV Azteca, 44%, 44%, 35% and 33%, for *Reforma*, *El Universal*, Radio Fórmula and W Radio, respectively. In a similar sense, 78% of our respondents believed that the information broadcast by Televisa is manipulated by the company due to its own interests. A total of 65%, 44%, 43%, 36%, and 34% believed that the information on TV Azteca, *El Universal*, *Reforma*, Radio Fórmula and W Radio, respectively, is manipulated by those media sources due to their own interests (see Figure 2.0). In contrast, only 5% believed that the information on Televisa is not manipulated by the government (the rest of the sample—11%—indicated that it did not have enough information to answer); 11% believed the same regarding TV Azteca. Although newspapers, such as *El Universal* and *Reforma*, and radio stations were more favorably ranked in our survey, they were only trusted by between 15 and 23% of the sample.

Interestingly, when we asked about media such as “television” or “radio” without mentioning a specific company, the level of trust among those surveyed tended to increase; 58% of our participants expressed that they trusted “television,” and 68% expressed that they trusted “the radio.” However, when we asked questions about specific traditional media outlets and included

the names of television, radio or newspaper companies, in 100% of the cases of the private national media that we investigated, our survey respondents mistrusted those media outlets more than they trusted them (see Figure 1.0). The public media outlet Channel 11, which belongs to the public university Instituto Politécnico Nacional, obtained different results: 32% of those surveyed trusted that what is broadcast by this media outlet is not manipulated by the government, and only 27% believed that the information broadcast by Channel 11 is manipulated. Finally, 39% of respondents perceived the international news network CNN as not manipulated by the government, while 25% believed that it was manipulated (which is certainly relevant, given that this 25% associates even CNN, an international media outlet, with being manipulated by the Mexican government).

Figure 1. Trust on the traditional news media (perceptions of manipulation by the government)

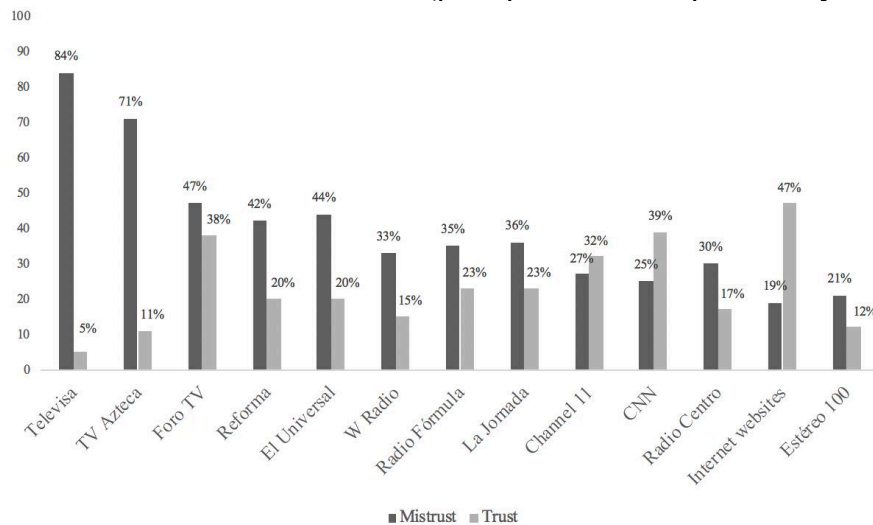
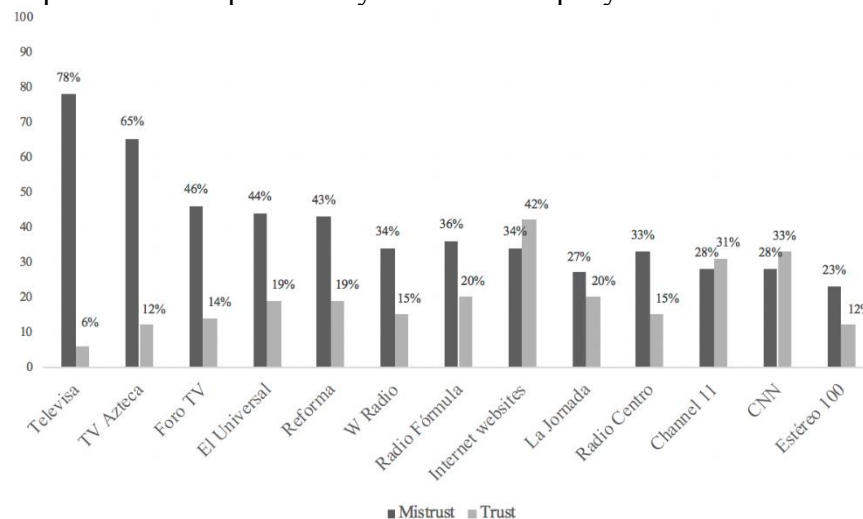


Figure 2. Trust on the traditional news media (perceptions of manipulation by the news company due to its own interests)



Consistent with all of the qualitative studies we have carried out (Phases 1 to 4 described above), 57% reported that they have more trust in the information they acquire through their own experiences and conversations with people they know than they do in the information that is transmitted through media such as television, radio or newspapers.

Beyond a lack of trust due to political factors or potential biases among the traditional news media, 62% of those surveyed stated that the media display excessive violence; 72% thought the media were sensationalist; and 73% thought the media were only seeking to sell their product and did not care about the quality of information they present.

These factors appear to influence the fact that a majority of respondents (55%) prefer programs related to music, culture, entertainment, or sports over accessing news.

With regard to the feelings the respondents perceive as the result of their contact with the news media, some of the results we found include annoyance in 28% of the sample, anger in 26%, stress due to fear in 22%, anxiety in 21%, sadness in 18%, despair in 15%. One in ten participants expressed apathy and repulsion after their contact with news media. These indicators are consistent with our exploratory PTSD suggestive symptoms investigation, which, as described above, detected those symptoms in approximately 20% of participants of a non-representative sample (Meschoulam & Calderon-Abbo, 2019).

Meanwhile, 19% indicated that the media produced in them feelings of calm, and 11% reported that the media give them feelings of happiness. This may be due to specific media with which the participants are in contact (as shown in the results from the statistical model described below). In this regard, consistent with the qualitative phase, those surveyed indicated that they felt drawn to media that demonstrate reliability (95%) and objectivity (93%), those that question the government or demonstrate distance from it (83%), and those that demonstrate journalistic rigor (83%). This quantitative investigation demonstrated a feature that was not detected in our qualitative phase, which is that 92% of respondents indicated that they felt drawn to media that publish information immediately following a certain event.

An essential topic that does maintain high consistency with the qualitative phase is that 90% of participants in the present study indicated that they valued media outlets that demonstrate respect for victims of violence; and 85% reported that it is the responsibility of the media to contribute to building peace but that they normally do not do so. Similarly, as was found in the qualitative phase, 74% of those surveyed preferred media outlets that combine news with entertainment (a factor that may be derived from the choice mentioned above to distance oneself from the news and instead opt for programs related to entertainment, sports or culture). Likewise, 73% of those surveyed indicated that they like for the media to present content on topics concerning the environment, sexual diversity, or human rights, which represent themes that emerged in our qualitative phase (see Table 2.0).

Table 2. Attributes that attract our participants to media

Attributes that attract our participants to media	Mentions
Reliability	95%
Objectivity	93%
Question the government or demonstrate distance from it	83%
Journalistic rigor	83%
Media that publish information immediately following a certain event	92%
Media that demonstrates respect for victims of violence	90%
Responsibility of the media to contribute to building peace but that they normally do not do so	85%
Combination of news with entertainment	74%
Topics concerning the environment, sexual diversity, or human rights	73%

In an attempt to disaggregate this apparently unitary entity called “the media,” our questionnaire also made contrasts between different media sources and between specific Mexican journalists, seeking to identify which of these presented the greatest positive or negative deviations from the mean. The results indicate that the participants tend to have far more mistrust of journalists associated with the main television broadcasters, Televisa and TV Azteca, while they tend to have much more trust in journalists associated with Channel 11 (Instituto Politécnico Nacional), CNN, or online news portals. One news channel owned by Televisa that has clearly succeeded in differentiating itself from the rest of the network is Foro TV, whose journalists scored well in our survey. Upon drawing contrasts between specific media outlets, Televisa and TV Azteca presented the greatest deviations with regard to being controlled by the government or their owners, broadcasting violent news, or demonstrating a lack of seriousness and journalistic rigor. The newspapers *Reforma* and *La Jornada* presented high deviation with regard to covering violent content excessively. As indicated below, web portals, on the other hand, were perceived as having greater independence from the traditional media and generated greater acceptance and reliability among those we surveyed. Regarding radio stations, with the exception of certain journalists who are perceived as serious and independent, the majority of the results were situated around the average.

Results Related to Social Media and Internet Websites

Our findings confirmed the relative ambiguity found in our qualitative phase in terms of feelings about social media, but now with a greater tendency toward mistrust of these media; 59% of those surveyed reported feeling mistrust in news published on social media, while 41% expressed that they do trust the news published on these platforms. Once again, 62% reported having more trust in the information they acquire through their own experience and that of those they know than they do in the information that is published on social networks.

However, worthy of separate mention is that concerning online news portals (not those associated with traditional media but, rather, independent portals such as *Animal Político* or *Aristegui*

Noticias in the Mexican case). Regarding these online portals, 81% of those surveyed believed that they are not manipulated by the government, while 76% believed that their information is objective. In our contrast and deviation tests, we detected that, according to our survey respondents, web portals such as those indicated are notably more reliable than are the traditional media, much more serious, and generally perceived as “the best media.” Moreover, our participants indicated identifying with their presenters/hosts/journalists much more consistently than with those of any other type of media.

Findings from our Statistical Model/Linear Regression

As expected, a significant correlation (0.72) was detected between the perception that the government manipulates the information and the degree of distrust in the traditional media news outlets. This was additionally supported by the statistical model we developed. The negative feeling index shows that the totality of our respondents expressed at least one negative feeling after their contact with the news media, and almost one in three participants expressed having all of the negative feelings we consulted after their contact with the news media. According to the linear regression test, the perception that the government manipulates information, and the perception that traditional media outlets also manipulate the information, predict negative feelings such as stress, frustration, apathy, fear, anger, anxiety, discomfort, repulsion, sadness and hopelessness after contact with the news media.

Similarly, as expected, the perception that traditional media sources display too much violence (yellow or sensationalist journalism) is a highly contributing factor in generating negative feelings after contact with those media sources. In contrast, the level of trust in specific media outlets, as well as the perception that a certain media outlet does not exhibit violence in excess, and contributes to building peace have a negative impact on the provocation of the undesirable feelings we measured.

Stated differently, distrust in the media seems to be directly associated with distrust in the government, specifically the feeling that both the government and the media manipulate the information. However, these perceptions do not seem to stop in distrust, but end up directly impacting on negative feelings perceived by many participants after their contact with the traditional mass media. Likewise, the perception that the Mexican mainstream news media outlets are sensationalist, is a predictor of negative feelings after contact with them, while, conversely, this series of negative feelings diminish after contact with media outlets that are perceived as contributors to building peace in the country. That may explain the fact that 19% of our respondents felt calmer and 7% felt more peaceful after their contact with the news media. Per our model, those are media outlets they trust and consider as peacebuilders.

Worthy of further mention, and probably an interesting source of reflection, is that one of the attributes that respondents assign to the media, which also ends up contributing to the generation of negative feelings, seems to be that their “content is entertaining”. Or, put differently, it seems that somehow, despite feeling bad after contact with traditional media, participants find that the contents of these media still entertain them.

VI. Discussion of results

The results confirmed our hypotheses with some nuances. Although a majority of participants expressed trust in the news transmitted on “television,” on “radio” or in the “newspapers,” as media in the abstract (without making reference to a particular media company), when those media were assigned a specific name, such as that of any of the two major television networks, radio broadcasts or newspaper outlets consumed in the country, the level of mistrust considerably exceeds the level of trust. Furthermore, the results confirm that (a) the perception that the government manipulates the information is correlated to the perception that the information is manipulated by the media sources themselves; (b) to the extent that these two perceptions exist, the greater is the likelihood of presence of negative feelings among audiences such as stress, frustration, apathy, fear, anger, anxiety, discomfort, repulsion, sadness and hopelessness following contact with such traditional media; (c) similarly, not only a majority of participants consider that the traditional media in Mexico exhibit violence excessively, but to the extent that these media are perceived as more yellowish or sensationalist, the greater the probability those negative feelings will be generated after being in contact with them. The latter is consistent with the analysis of the in-depth interviews conducted in the qualitative phase prior to this investigation. Likewise, the present study confirms that a majority of participants value their own experience and observation, conversation with close people, or the experience of close people as sources of information, rather than that obtained from traditional media. Also, a majority of participants prefer to access musical, cultural entertainment or sports programs in contrast to news. Regarding the factors that attract participants to specific media outlets, it was confirmed that a majority of Mexicans seem to value media that show objectivity, seriousness, journalistic rigor, reliability, and distance from government, in addition to treating their audiences with respect, as well as the victims of violence with respect. These factors—associated with what is known as *peace journalism*—seem to contribute to this other finding from our research: the greater the perception that certain media outlet contributes to building peace, to that extent, negative feelings such as stress, frustration, apathy, fear, anger, anxiety, discomfort, repulsion, sadness and hopelessness are less present after contact with that particular media source.

The results of this study reflect the fact that the distancing we detected in limited samples in our previous studies between participants and mass media, seems to be a generalized phenomenon in Mexican society, specifically with regard to traditional media outlets including the two major television networks in the country and some other media outlets in radio and print journalism. According to the findings presented, this is reflected not always through not tuning into channels or stations, and hence, it is not a matter of ratings. In fact, as we observed in the profile of our survey respondents concerning their media consumption, it is clear that, in Mexico, traditional media continue to be very much used to obtain information. It is instead a psychological and political distancing between the citizens and certain traditional media sources that audiences appear to associate with the elites in power in the country. The participants frequently access the news through these media, but they strongly mistrust them given that they believe that they are manipulated by the government or by the interests of the media outlets themselves. Likewise, as was detected in the study about symptoms suggesting posttraumatic stress that we carried out in 2011 (Meschoulam & Calderon-Abbo, 2019, 49), contact with the news tends to produce stress among the participants a manifestation which, combined with other negative feelings, seems to intensify to the extent that there is distrust in the government and in the media because of the belief

that they manipulate the information, and to the extent that there is a perceived excessive display of violence by those media sources. Moreover, in their view, the majority of the traditional media sources disrupt peace and provoke negative feelings, which may lead them to prefer programs related to entertainment, sports or culture rather than accessing news. In short, the results indicate a distancing as a result of mistrust, perceived sensationalism, and feelings such as anger, anxiety, despair and stress, which in the perception of participants—regardless of whether this is true or not—are caused by these media.

Additionally, in our previous studies, social media appeared as spaces to strengthen conversations and find out about news through alternatives sources not connected to the circles of power. Since 2017, however, the findings indicate that this trend could be reversing due to the high presence of mistrust in social networks by participants. The reason for this mistrust is linked to a lack of control perceived with regard to the propagation of rumors and fake news on one hand, and the occupation of social media by the traditional media and powerful groups in the country on the other. The quantitative research that we present in this article not only detected signs of that mistrust, but also demonstrated that this mistrust is even more present than we initially thought. Interestingly, nine out of ten of those surveyed use social media to obtain information; however, the majority of them report mistrusting that information. Once again, then, it is not about distancing that can be reflected in the number of clicks but, rather, a psychological distancing. It would seem that these participants access news that they do not believe or do not believe entirely.

As a result, Mexican citizens appear to rely much more on their own experiences, conversations with their associates and the experiences of people they know, to socially construct their perceptions regarding what is happening in the country, especially on issues related to violence, although not only about those issues.

As we explained previously, this is enormously delicate for at least two reasons: (a) Democracies need informed citizenries that are interested in public affairs and willing to participate in them; however, it is impossible for citizens to be well-informed based only on their own experiences, daily conversations, and the experiences of people they know. A healthy and fluid relationship between society and the media is thus an indispensable condition that Mexico currently appears to lack. This characterizes, at least, the relationship between the citizenry and the media most used to consume news; and (b) the free flow of information is one of the necessary conditions for building positive peace in a society (IEP, 2018, 8). To the extent that a majority of citizens believe that the information is manipulated by the government or by the media themselves and that social networks are unreliable sources of information, there is an absence, or a perceived absence, of the free flow of information, which instead of contributing to building peace does precisely the opposite.

Nevertheless, the results of this research, especially if we combine them with those of our previous studies, also give us some clues to how these trends could be reversed. Mexican citizens highly value those media sources that demonstrate objectivity and journalistic rigor, that question the authorities, and that demonstrate adequate distance between the media outlet and the government (or powerful elites). The more a media source can effectively communicate that it possesses those attributes, the more likely it is to capture and maintain its audiences.

It is understood that there is a broad debate about what the role of the media should be in covering the violence and events that unfortunately do occur that disturb the peace (Barreto, Borja, Serrano, & López-López, 2009; Becker-Blease, Finkelhor, & Turner, 2008; Bernabé, 2011; Bongar, Brown, Beutler, Breckenridge, & Zimbardo, 2007; Choi & James, 2007; Ewart, 2012; Farnen, 1990; Galtung, Lynch, & McGoldrick, 2006; Gilboa, 2009). However, and very much apart from that debate, the results of the qualitative phases as well as those of this quantitative study seem to indicate that Mexican citizens place significant value on a media source that demonstrates respect for the victims of violence, avoids sensationalism and instead contributes to building peace in the country. What follows, then, is to ask if there can be a balance between the great imperative for the media to cover events that occur with the demand of citizens for objective coverage that places less emphasis on blood and more on building peace. In our previous publications, we made a series of recommendations on those areas. The results of this study contribute evidence to support those recommendations including *peace journalism*. A summary of these recommendations include those covered in the following section (summarized from Meschoulam, 2019).

VII. Recommendations

1. Government communication. The findings of this study should be disseminated among officials and those responsible for government communication; trainings should be carried out in this sector in order to value the shared responsibility with regard to the prevalence of mistrust in the media and with regard to the propagation of collective fear, to evaluate the possibilities for free yet coordinated efforts to counteract these trends. Officials should avoid generating information vacuums during times of crisis and communicate violent events in a way that is timely, truthful, and credible while balancing the need to inform with an attempt to avoid propagating panic, rumors or fake news. The training of those officials should include methods to inform the public about what is being done to contain the violence crisis as well as alternatives to resolve the situation. This also entails the need to train public officials on integral peacebuilding (positive peace)—vis a vis reducing violence (negative peace)—in order to demonstrate to citizens that it is understood that the root cause of the circumstances of violence plaguing Mexico is structural factors—such as inequality, corruption and impunity—that must be addressed in the short, medium and long term.
2. Improve (and communicate) the transparency and credibility of public institutions. This includes demonstrating, on the part of the government, distance between the authorities and the media, allowing the media to conduct themselves with freedom and independence and to question the authorities with complete flexibility whenever it is needed, responding adequately to citizens' inquiries and offering credible and timely explanations or, even, recognizing errors or omissions. These proposals, far from being “idealistic” or unviable, according to our studies offer real and tangible incentives for political actors, given that they would considerably increase positive appraisals of their performance. Hiding information, masking realities, or evading explanations are counterproductive communication strategies according to the evidence we present.
3. The media must strengthen their trustworthiness, demonstrating clear independence from political actors or interest groups, objectivity and absolute journalistic rigor in the management of information. This entails questioning the authorities whenever it is necessary, promoting

critical thinking, offering spaces for debate demonstrating openness to diverse positions, and strengthening investigative journalism to reveal problems of corruption or structural issues in the country. This recommendation has to do not only with an interest in public affairs, but also business: the need to acquire and preserve the loyalty of audiences that highly value the elements stated. This is even more relevant in times in which the competition offered by online spaces are valued as much more reliable by citizens, as demonstrated by the evidence we shared in this study.

4. Similarly, regarding the coverage of violence, moderation is recommended in terms of images, videos and the treatment of victims (Restrepo, 2004). The evidence from this study indicates that showing empathy for those affected, their relatives and communities, without denigrating their image or identity and without assuming culpability or responsibility for events that have not been investigated, are elements that are highly valued by citizens.
5. In line with the proposals of *peace journalism* (Galtung, Lynch, & McGoldrick, 2006), it is recommended to report on violence in a way that is complete, truthful and timely, but that does not focus exclusively on the violence itself; the reports should seek to cover the underlying structural factors, the causes of the violence, and, at the same time, promote analysis and debate regarding potential solutions or alternatives to resolve or, at least, lessen that violence and its effects. To do this, it is suggested to invite experts and strengthen investigative journalism that seeks answers regarding how cycles of violence are fed as well as possibilities for halting them and building positive peace in a society. This measure is widely backed by both the in-depth interviews we carried out in the qualitative phases and the findings of this study.
6. Seek adequate balance between hard news on violence and content considered softer or regarding other topics. Some authors propose *decentering* the news agenda (Pries-Shimishi, 2005). That is, without ceasing to cover the violence, balance news coverage adequately with relevant information regarding diverse topics ranging from politics and the economy to other important issues that exist in a country. In line with this, our research appears to contribute an additional element. Citizens appear to tend to seek out programs related to music and entertainment instead of news because of the level of stress that they feel it causes. Therefore, it is recommended that components of softer coverage be included, such as gender diversity, the environment, technological advances, film, art, music and sports, as elements within news programs. Perhaps one could argue that there are already programs or sections in newspapers that address these topics. It is true. However, our results indicate that, in the view of our participants, coverage of violence continues to be disproportionate and, in their opinion, the news programs in spaces such as radio and television should include a greater selection of these topics combined or interspersed with coverage of violence.

VIII. Recommendations for future research

We assume that several of the results detected in a nationally representative sample in Mexico could be found in other countries. This is relevant at the time of this writing in which broad sectors of populations from different parts of the world seem to exhibit some degree of distrust of traditional media in their own countries (Edelman Trust Barometer, 2019). The recommendation would be to conduct in-depth interviews such as those we have carried out in recent years, and

apply quantitative instruments similar to the one we used for this research. This can be done in areas that suffer from armed conflict or circumstances of violence such as Mexico, or in countries with higher levels of political and social stability. Similarly, it is recommended to deepen, both in Mexico and in other parts of the world, in the investigation of issues such as social media, based on the results of our research. Finally, as noted above, it would be worth replicating this same investigation, after a period of at least one or two years with Andrés Manuel López Obrador in office in Mexico.

IX. Conclusions

The results of this study validate, in general terms, the findings of the qualitative research phase we carried out in 2017, now among a representative national sample in Mexico. This implies that the perceived distancing between citizens and the traditional news media, especially those that are most watched, listened to or read, is not an isolated issue but, rather, a manifestation that describes, to a large extent, the relationship that exists today between the Mexican population and the mechanisms they use to remain informed about what is happening in the country. The present investigation adds evidence that demonstrates that the source of the negative feelings that the audiences present after their contact with the media (and hence, their preference to disconnect from the news and access other types of content) is directly related to mistrust regarding the manipulation of information and perceived yellow journalism or sensationalism.

This has serious implications not only for democracy and freedom but also for the possibility of building peace from the ground up in one of the least peaceful countries in the world. As we have explained, peace is not limited to the absence of violence, and hence, factors such as the propagation of fear, with all of the psychosocial effects this entails, and the need that exists for a positive relationship between citizens and mass media are issues that should be dealt with the same level of priority as combating crime or strategies to contain and reduce the waves of violence that have characterized the country since 2006. This study appears to demonstrate that Mexico is far from adequately addressing these factors and that the majority of the population prefers to distance itself from information or, at least, the traditional routes for accessing information. Instead, they privilege other types of mechanisms for socially constructing their perceptions and ideas about violence and peace, such as individual experiences, conversations with people with whom they are close, or the experiences of their associates. When citizens do decide to access the media, they generally choose music, culture, sports or entertainment programs, or they read or listen to news that they mostly appear to mistrust. Moreover, contact with major media sources frequently generates stress, anger, anxiety, despair, fear or other negative feelings that distance those citizens even more from the information.

Due to the relevance of these findings with regard to violence and peace, it is indispensable to consider and put in place a series of parallel measures—involving both the media and other social sectors—that are aimed at reducing the impact of the propagation of fear and at promoting elements that foster closeness between Mexican citizens and the traditional media and facilitate not only the free flow of information but also the desire and willingness of the population to access that free flow of information. This study, particularly if it is read in conjunction with the qualitative research that precedes it, provides evidence that can offer some keys for those social actors.

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